
RUSSIAN TORTOISE

Testudo horsfieldii



Intermediate

Complete Care Package

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BeastlyFacts

Practical care guides for curious animal lovers

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How to Use This Package

This package is a practical owner manual, not a textbook. Read the Quick Profile and Care Guide once to understand the setup. Then use the checklists, temperature targets, and symptom reference as working tools.

Russian tortoises are a multi-decade commitment (40-80+ years). This is intermediate care mainly because of space, UVB discipline, diet quality, and the decision around brumation - not because the animal is fragile day to day.

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1. Quick Profile

The Russian tortoise (*Testudo horsfieldii*), also called Horsfield's or Central Asian tortoise, is native to the arid steppes and rocky deserts from Kazakhstan to Pakistan and China. It is one of the world's most cold-tolerant tortoises, surviving extreme temperature swings by hibernating deep underground for months. Adults reach 5-8 inches. Captive lifespan is typically 40-80 years. IUCN status: Vulnerable.

Native Range	Central Asia (Kazakhstan to China / Pakistan)
Natural Habitat	Semi-arid steppe, rocky desert, dry scrubland
Adult Size	5-8 inches (13-20 cm)
Wild Diet	Grasses, leaves, flowers, plant matter
Captive Diet	Hay + weeds / fibrous leafy greens
Typical Lifespan	40-80+ years
Difficulty	Intermediate
Conservation	Vulnerable (IUCN)

Fun Facts

- Among the smallest and hardiest commonly kept tortoises.
 - Survives sub-zero temperatures by hibernating deep underground for months.
 - Adopting one is a lifelong (multi-decade) commitment - some exceed 100 years.
 - Talented escape artists and diggers despite their slow reputation.
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Cost Overview

A full indoor setup typically runs \$400-600 before the tortoise (tortoise table, UVB, basking, substrate, hides, monitoring). Captive-bred animals cost about \$50-150 for hatchlings/young and \$225-400 for older individuals. Ongoing annual costs are roughly \$500-650 for food, substrate, and electricity. Prefer captive-bred over wild-caught.

2. Full Care Guide

Housing & Enclosure

Indoor absolute minimum: 4x2 feet open-top tortoise table for one adult; a more comfortable functional size is about 7x3.5 feet. Open-topped tables are strongly preferred over glass aquariums (better ventilation, less stress from visible barriers they cannot cross).

Outdoor pens (when climate allows) are the gold standard: walls high enough and buried at least 12 inches to stop escape tunnels. Provide natural grass, plantain, dandelion, and clover for the richest diet and enrichment. Secure lids or covers against predators where needed.

Never house multiple males together - they are territorial and will ram and bully. Do not use closed glass aquariums long-term.



Example Russian tortoise enclosure setup

Temperature, UVB & Humidity

Basking surface 95-100°F (some sources 90-100°F). Cool side in the 70s°F. Night drops to around 60°F are tolerated without supplemental night heat. Brumation, if chosen, is typically managed at 40-55°F under a safe protocol with a tortoise-experienced vet.

Strong UVB is required: T5 HO tube (Arcadia 12% or Zoo Med ReptiSun 10.0) in a reflective fixture covering roughly a third to half the enclosure length. Target basking-area UVI about 3.0-4.0. Avoid coil or compact UVB bulbs. Replace on the manufacturer's schedule.

Ambient humidity 30-50%. This is an arid-adapted species - high ambient humidity drives respiratory infection. Always provide a moist hide (peat or sphagnum) on the cool end for a humid microclimate used for hydration and shedding.

Substrate & Furnishings

Deep diggable substrate is both enrichment and welfare: 50/50 topsoil + coconut coir (or sandy loam), ideally 6-12+ inches in at least one zone or a dedicated dig box. Keep slightly moist rather than bone dry. **Never** use pure sand as the sole substrate (mobility and impaction concerns). Avoid rabbit pellets and newspaper-only long-term setups.

Provide multiple hides oriented in different directions (warm side + cool/humid side), large hollow logs, cork flats, flat stones, and low obstacles. Russians are surprisingly good climbers and will use modest elevation changes.

Diet & Feeding

Almost entirely herbivorous. Foundation: unlimited grass hay (Timothy, orchard, or meadow) plus dark leafy greens and edible weeds - dandelion greens and flowers, clover, plantain weed, endive, escarole, mustard greens, collard greens. Weeds and fibrous leafy greens should dominate.

Dust food with calcium without D3 at most feedings; calcium with D3 about twice weekly. Provide cuttlebone. Fresh water in a shallow dish always accessible. Weekly soaking in shallow warm water for 20-30 minutes supports hydration.

Never use high-protein foods or commercial tortoise pellets as the primary diet. Avoid high-oxalate staples (spinach, beet greens). Fruit less than 5% of the diet. Excess protein and fruit drive pyramiding.

Handling

Russian tortoises are better as observation pets. Keep physical interaction purposeful and infrequent - over-handling causes real stress. Approach carefully. They are active, curious climbers and burrowers, and better escape artists than their reputation suggests.

Enrichment

Enrichment centers on three species-typical behaviors: burrowing, foraging/grazing, and exploration of three-dimensional space.

Burrowing is critical: deep diggable substrate (6-12+ inches in at least one zone) and pre-formed or partially buried hides the tortoise can expand. Outdoor pens need walls buried at least 12 inches.

Foraging: scatter-feed weeds and greens in multiple locations rather than a single bowl. Use forage mats or crumpled towels with greens tucked into folds. Plant safe edible weeds outdoors or in rotatable pots. Occasional puzzle presentation (greens under light obstacles) adds challenge.

Spatial: multiple hides, hollow logs, cork flats, flat stones, gentle slopes, and occasional rearrangement of non-critical decor (every 1-4 weeks). Outdoor access with natural sunlight and real soil multiplies all of these benefits when climate and security allow.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Never** prevent brumation without veterinary guidance if the animal is geared for it - forced year-round activity can cause reproductive and longevity problems.
- **Never** use pure sand as the sole substrate, or rabbit pellets / newspaper as long-term substrate.
- **Never** keep ambient humidity high - this species is arid-adapted.
- **Never** make high-protein foods or fruit the bulk of the diet.
- **Never** house multiple males together.
- **Never** rely on coil UVB bulbs or skip UVB replacement schedules.
- **Never** use a closed glass aquarium as the primary long-term home.

3. Health & Common Issues

Most Russian tortoise problems track to UVB, diet quality, temperature, and humidity. Annual wellness checks with a tortoise-experienced vet are essential. Any newly acquired animal should get a fecal test whether or not symptoms are present.

Red Flags - Act Early

- Soft or deformed shell, weak limbs (possible MBD).
 - Wheezing, nasal discharge, open-mouth breathing, lethargy (respiratory infection - urgent).
 - Soft, discolored, or foul-smelling shell patches (shell rot - can progress to septicemia).
 - Raised, cone-shaped scutes (pyramiding - irreversible once present).
 - Sustained appetite loss, weight loss, or abnormal stools.
-

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD)

From inadequate UVB or insufficient dietary calcium. Signs: soft or deformed shell, weak limbs.

Prevention

- Consistent strong linear UVB replaced on a calendar
- Cuttlebone free-choice + dusting as directed
- Correct basking surface temperatures

What to do

- Verify UVB age, distance, and basking temp immediately
- Contact a tortoise-experienced vet promptly

What not to do

- Never rely on coil UVB or window sunlight alone
-

Pyramiding

Raised cone-shaped scute growth from excess protein, overfeeding, poor hydration/humidity management, or calcium deficiency. Permanent once present.

Prevention

- Hay and fibrous weeds as the diet foundation
- Steady growth rate - do not force feed for size
- Correct calcium/UVB and humidity management

What not to do

- Never use high-protein pet-store mixes as the staple diet

Respiratory Infection & Shell Rot

Respiratory infection tracks to chronically low temperatures, excess humidity, or drafts. Signs: wheezing, nasal discharge, open-mouth breathing, lethargy. Requires veterinary care - does not resolve on its own.

Shell rot is bacterial or fungal infection through cuts or scrapes, often worsened by a damp enclosure. Soft, discolored, or foul-smelling patches need a vet; untreated cases can progress to septicemia.

What to do

- Correct temperature and humidity immediately
- Contact a tortoise-experienced vet the same day for breathing issues

What not to do

- Never wait out open-mouth breathing or foul shell patches
-

Parasites

Roundworms and protozoa are common in wild-caught animals. Run a fecal test on every newly acquired tortoise. Treat only under veterinary guidance.

What to do

- Fecal test on intake and after any weight loss or abnormal stool
- Quarantine new animals away from established ones

What not to do

- Never dose over-the-counter dewormers without a vet and diagnosis

Brumation (Seasonal Slowdown)

Many Russian tortoises slow down or burrow deeply in cooler months. This can be normal - but only for healthy, well-weighted animals after illness is ruled out. A thin, lethargic, or symptomatic tortoise is not ready to brumate.

Before you allow or induce brumation

- Weight is stable and body condition is good
- Recent fecal check is clean (or treated and cleared)
- No red-flag symptoms (discharge, soft shell, weakness)
- Prefer a tortoise-experienced vet exam first when unsure

If brumation is confirmed and the tortoise is healthy

- Follow a vet-guided protocol - typically cool stable temps, not a garage guess
- Keep the animal secure from predators, flooding, and freezing if outdoors
- Weigh before, during (as practical), and after; log dates
- Indoor year-round without brumation is acceptable if UVB, diet, and space stay correct

Call the vet

- Any weight loss during the slowdown
- Discharge, labored breathing, or soft shell
- You cannot confirm the tortoise was healthy going in
- First-time keepers unsure about outdoor overwintering safety

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential Setup Checklist

- Open-top tortoise table min 4x2 ft (larger preferred) or secure outdoor pen
- Deep diggable substrate 6-12+ in (50/50 topsoil + coir or sandy loam)
- T5 HO UVB (Arcadia 12% or ReptiSun 10.0) in reflective fixture
- Halogen or ceramic basking to 95-100°F surface
- Digital thermometer(s) + hygrometer
- Multiple hides including a moist hide on the cool end
- Shallow water dish + weekly soak routine
- Grass hay + weed/green supply + calcium (with and without D3) + cuttlebone
- Outdoor walls buried ≥ 12 in if outdoor housing

Temperature & Climate Targets

Zone	Target	Notes
Basking surface	95-100°F	Measure at the surface
Cool side	70s°F	Allow choice
Night drop	~60°F	Usually no night heat needed
Ambient humidity	30-50%	High ambient humidity is harmful
UVB	T5 HO 10-12%	UVI ~3.0-4.0 at basking; no coils

Emergency & Quick Targets - Russian Tortoise

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. When something looks wrong, start here.

Quick Targets

Parameter	Target
Basking surface	95-100°F
Cool side	70s°F
Night drop	~60°F ok
Ambient humidity	30-50%
UVB	T5 HO 10-12%, UVI ~3-4
Soak	Weekly 20-30 min warm shallow water

Red Flags - Act Early

- Soft or deformed shell, weak limbs (MBD)
- Nasal discharge, wheezing, open-mouth breathing
- Soft, foul, or discolored shell patches (shell rot)
- Raised cone-shaped scutes (pyramiding)
- Sustained appetite loss or weight loss
- Lethargy with low temps or high humidity

Do This Now

- Correct basking temp and UVB immediately
- Lower ambient humidity if damp; offer soak
- Contact tortoise-experienced vet with photos + weights

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget & Shopping List

Indoor setup \$400-600 before the animal. Annual ongoing roughly \$500-650. Plan for multi-decade ownership - this is not a short-term pet. Captive-bred preferred. Routine exotic-vet checkup around \$75; illness workups \$150-300+.

Shopping checklist

- Open-top tortoise table 4x2+ ft (or outdoor pen materials)
- Deep substrate (topsoil + coconut coir)
- T5 HO UVB fixture + 10.0/12% bulb
- Basking bulb/fixture to reach 95-100°F surface
- Digital thermometer + hygrometer
- Hides (including moist hide materials)
- Shallow water dish
- Grass hay + weed/green sources
- Calcium with and without D3 + cuttlebone
- Gram scale for weight tracking

First 30 Days Checklist

- Set up enclosure and stabilize temperatures and UVB before the tortoise arrives
 - Quarantine and schedule a fecal exam with a tortoise-experienced vet
 - Establish hay + weed/green feeding and weekly soaks
 - Confirm the tortoise is exploring, eating, and producing normal stools
 - Locate long-term outdoor options if climate allows
 - Begin weight tracking on a gram scale
-

Symptom Quick Reference

Sign	Possible Cause	Action
Soft shell / weak limbs	MBD	Check UVB + calcium; see vet
Nasal discharge / wheezing	Respiratory infection	Raise temps; vet antibiotics
Soft foul shell patches	Shell rot	Dry conditions; see vet
Raised cone scutes	Pyramiding	Fix diet/growth; irreversible
Appetite loss / weight drop	Multiple causes	Check temps, then vet

Daily & Weekly Routine

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. Consistency matters more than perfection.

Daily

- Check basking surface temperature (95-100°F) and cool side
 - Confirm UVB is on schedule
 - Offer fresh weeds/greens and hay; scatter-feed when possible
 - Check water dish; refresh if soiled
 - Quick visual check: eyes, shell, limbs, breathing, energy
-

Weekly

- Soak 20-30 minutes in shallow warm water
 - Spot-clean substrate and high-contact surfaces
 - Weigh and log if tracking growth
 - Rotate forage locations; check dig areas stay usable
 - Inspect shell for soft spots, discharge, or pyramiding changes
-

Every 6-12 Months

- Replace UVB bulb on calendar - do not wait for visible dimming
- Annual wellness visit + fecal with a tortoise-experienced vet
- Recheck thermostat/fixture condition; reassess outdoor access seasonally

Last changed / logged dates (write in):

UVB bulb replaced: _____ Next due: _____

Last vet visit: _____ Last weight: _____

Owner Log - Russian Tortoise

Track weight and basic daily notes. Weight change is often the earliest warning sign. Print extra copies as needed.

Weight & Daily Log

Date	Weight (g)	Ate?	Soak?	Notes

Brumation Decision Notes

- Only consider brumation for healthy, well-weighted animals after a vet check and fecal.
- A thin, lethargic, or symptomatic tortoise is not 'ready to brumate' - treat husbandry/health first.
- If you brumate: follow a tortoise-experienced vet protocol (typically cool stable temps, not a garage guess).
- Indoor year-round without brumation is acceptable for many keepers if UVB, diet, and space stay correct.

Enrichment Checklist - Russian Tortoise

Enrichment is not optional decoration. Use this as a setup and monthly review checklist.

Setup & Ongoing Checklist

- Deep diggable zone 6-12+ inches (or dig box)
- Scatter-feed weeds/greens in multiple locations
- Rotate forage spots daily or every other day
- Hides on warm side AND cool/humid side
- Hollow logs, cork flats, flat stones, gentle slopes
- Rearrange non-critical decor every 1-4 weeks
- Never move primary hides during rearranges
- Outdoor pen when climate allows (walls buried ≥ 12 in)

Monthly review notes (write in):

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Rule: stability for core hides/heat/water systems; novelty only in non-critical items.

Glossary

Brumation - Reptile winter dormancy; in Russians often involves deep burrowing for months.

Cuttlebone - Natural calcium source offered free-choice.

MBD - Metabolic Bone Disease from calcium or UVB deficiency.

Pyramiding - Raised, cone-shaped growth of shell scutes from diet/growth problems; irreversible.

Tortoise table - Open-top indoor enclosure preferred for ventilation and space.

UVI - UV Index - measure of UVB intensity at the basking area.

This care package was compiled from BeastlyFacts research and practical husbandry standards.

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Disclaimer: This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Husbandry standards evolve; always verify critical health decisions with a qualified exotic/aquatic veterinarian.

No external links are included in this document.
